

FILM STUDIES

An Introduction

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CHAPTER 10

GENRE

WHAT IS A GENRE?

GENRE (zhon'-ruh): *a type or category of film—such as the western, the horror film, the comedy, or the musical—that has its own recognizable conventions and character types.*

To return to a point raised while defining the term CONVENTION ([chapter 7](#)), we sometimes assume that art is about pure creativity—that great films (or novels, or paintings, or musical works) are a matter of complete originality. But genres belie that idea. Genres rely on repetition and variation rather than uniqueness—familiar, recognizable *conventions* rather than raw, pure *inventions*. It's true that a filmmaker may take an especially fresh approach to a genre by emphasizing an unexpected element, spinning a seemingly predictable story in a new and unusual direction, or having a central character behave in an unconventional way. But these are *variations*, not radical innovations. In a way, a film genre is rather like a language we all understand. One could make up an entirely new word, but nobody else would know what it means. It's the repetitive nature of language that enables it to have meaning and make communication possible. The same holds true for film genres.

The word *genre* comes from French, where it simply means *kind* or *type*. You may be familiar with the word *generic*, which is used to describe medicines and other products that are sold without a brand name. Tylenol is an individual brand name, for instance, but Tylenol's active ingredient, acetaminophen—a kind or type of pain reliever—is also sold in unbranded, *generic* form. You may also know the word

genus in biology. A *genus* is a category of organism that falls on the taxonomic (or classificational) scale between *family* and *species*. (*Homo* is our genus, *sapiens* our species.) All of these terms—genre, generic, and genus—refer to ways of categorizing things according to their resemblance to each other. It's sometimes said that it is our differences that define us as individuals, but in genre criticism it's really quite the opposite: genres are defined by the similarities among a large number of films.

Critics have identified innumerable genres and subgenres over the years, from the action film (*Captain Blood*, 1934; *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom*, 1984; *Lara Croft: Tomb Raider*, 2001) and the baseball picture (*Bull Durham*, 1988; *The Natural*, 1984; *The Jackie Robinson Story*, 1950, which is also a biographical picture, or *biopic*) to the thriller (Alfred Hitchcock's *North by Northwest*, 1959; *Phone Booth*, 2003; *Angels and Demons*, 2009) and the women's prison picture (*Caged*, 1950; *Women's Prison*, 1955; *Caged Heat*, 1974). There are martial arts films, chick flicks, beach party pictures, costume dramas, sci-fi films, and slapstick comedies. There is a genre called the *blaxploitation film*, which began with Melvin Van Peebles' *Sweet Sweetback's Baadasssss Song* (1971) and continued with such films as Gordon Parks's *Shaft* (1971) and Quentin Tarantino's *Jackie Brown* (1997), though one might very well question the genre's name on the grounds that seeking African American audiences for films featuring African American action heroes is scarcely more exploitive than any other attempt to target a particular audience.

Many of the best films ever made are genre pictures. John Ford's *Stagecoach* (1939) is a western; Alfred Hitchcock's *Psycho* (1960) is a horror film; George Cukor's *A Star is Born* (1954) is a musical; Martin Scorsese's *Goodfellas* (1990) is a gangster picture. Each of these films has something original about it, but all of them depend on genre conventions to provide meaning and structure. Not all films fall readily into specific genres. *Citizen Kane* (1941) is a *drama*, one of the broadest possible genre categories, but as many scholars have noted, it contains elements of both the *mystery* and the *film noir* genres.

CONVENTIONS, REPETITIONS, AND VARIATIONS

A **convention** is *a widely used and accepted device in an art form*. Film reviewers often use the term *conventional* as a put-down, a way of saying that they are tired of seeing the same technique, story element, or character type over and over onscreen. But film studies uses *conventional* in a nonjudgmental way. We see conventions not as exhausted clichés but as essential and valuable parts of a communication system, meaningful components in a wide network of shared ideas. In short, conventions are basic to culture, particularly popular culture. To repeat the definition provided earlier in this book, a convention is *an artistic practice or process or device that is commonly accepted and understood within a given culture*. Conventions are meaningful precisely because they are repetitive; if an artistic device was truly new and utterly unique, chances are we wouldn't understand it at all.

If the same character type appeared in the same costume and performed the same physical actions in the same general setting in film after film after film, some people might grow bored. But other people would remain interested—hence the profusion of similar westerns in the 1930s. The pleasure of reexperiencing the same basic genre elements in film over and over again—in this case, a cowboy, a horse, some sagebrush, an outlaw and/or some Indians—is not solely the province of the distant past. Think about the many commercially successful incarnations of the psychotic Michael Meyers in the *Halloween* horror series and the like (subgenre: the [SLASHER FILM](#)), or his equally crazed kin in the related but even more gruesome subgenre known as the SPLATTER MOVIE. Middlebrow critics may have yawned (and published their yawns as movie reviews), but audiences kept buying tickets to slasher and splatter movies, knowing more or less exactly what they were going to see and hear before they actually saw or heard it. That familiarity was part of their pleasure.

A **subgenre** is simply a smaller category within a genre category. The horror film has subgenres including the slasher movie, the splatter movie, and the monster movie (*Godzilla vs. Mothra*, 1964).

Comedies can be categorized into subgenres such as the screwball comedy (*Bringing Up Baby*, 1938), the gross-out comedy (*Dumb and Dumber*, 1994), the black comedy (*Dr. Strangelove: or How I Learned to Stop Worrying and Love the Bomb*, 1964), and other subgenres.

Repetition: the repetition of genre conventions from film to film provides a built-in structure, a recognizable framework in which not only the filmmakers but audiences operate. Seen from this perspective, genre conventions support rather than challenge social, cultural, and artistic assumptions. When we see a western, for example, we are not surprised to meet a protagonist onscreen who embodies a certain kind of idealized man: strong, tough, individualistic, taciturn ... The classical western hero is reassuring in his familiarity. This character has appeared in film after film for almost a century, even though he has been played by such diverse figures as John Wayne (*Fort Apache*, 1948), Clint Eastwood (*Unforgiven*, 1992), and Heath Ledger (*Brokeback Mountain*, 2005). Each of these stars, and each of these films, reinforces social and cultural expectations about masculinity, for example, by way of physiognomy and performance style. The repetition of this character type is so basic to the western genre that it is impossible to imagine a western featuring as its hero, say, a very sweet, extremely short singing sheriff who rides around a frontier town on an adorable little Shetland pony. (Impossible perhaps for first-time film students, but not for those seasoned veterans who have seen the 1938 all-midget western *The Terror of Tiny Town*.)

Variation: at the same time, repetition is never purely so. Every new western, or screwball comedy, or splatter movie, brings *variation*. Each particular story (or plot, or location, or actor, or line of dialogue) constitutes a dissimilarity from other films in the genre or subgenre. Each iteration is unique. In *Fort Apache*, for instance, John Wayne's character, Capt. Kirby York, closes the film by upholding a moral and ethical position—the value of traditional leadership—that the film has severely questioned until that point; York thus defends certain conservative ideas about masculinity. In *Unforgiven*, Clint Eastwood's character, Bill Munny, ends up going on

a murderous, bloody rampage, unleashing all his pent-up energy by slaughtering a number of other men in a spectacular, climactic shoot-out; this, too, is a statement about masculinity, but it's clearly quite different than that of *Fort Apache*. And finally, although Heath Ledger's character in *Brokeback Mountain*, Ennis Del Mar, may look and talk like a classical American film cowboy (Ennis is technically a ranch hand, not a cowboy), his love for another man sets him distinctly apart from conservative notions of western heroism, not to mention conventional masculinity. All three films are westerns, all three begin with similar characters, and yet each has something quite different to say about what it means to be a man: repetition and variation.

A BRIEF TAXONOMY OF TWO FILM GENRES—THE WESTERN AND THE HORROR FILM

Here is a partial breakdown of two popular genres, the western and the horror film, and some of the subgenres into which they can be divided. The list is certainly not comprehensive, and the specific films listed in each subgenre are by no means the only examples available. They're offered simply to give you a sense of what repetition and variation means in specific cinematic instances:

THE WESTERN

In general, the western is a film that takes place in the nineteenth-century American West.¹

Subgenre: Cowboys-and-Indians movie—racial and imperial conflict on the frontier

Broken Arrow (1950)

Drums Across the River (1954)

Cheyenne Autumn (1964)

Subgenre: Vengeance western—a loner, sometimes an outlaw, seeks revenge

Stagecoach (1939)

One-Eyed Jacks (1961)

The Outlaw Josey Wales (1976)

Subgenre: Spaghetti western—a western made by an Italian director and characterized by a certain pastiche quality, meaning that it seems to be quoting or even parodying classical American westerns

The Good, the Bad, and the Ugly (1966)
Django (1966)
Compañeros (1970)
Django and Sartana are Coming: It's the End! (1970)
Subgenre: Science-fiction western—the future meets the past in the American West
Westworld (1973)
Back to the Future III (1990)
Oblivion (1994)

THE HORROR FILM

The horror film induces fright or terror in an audience.²

Subgenre: Monster movie—a creature wrecks havoc

Bride of Frankenstein (1935)
Bride of the Monster (1955)
Bride of Chucky (1998)

Subgenre: Monster-as-psychotic-human movie—the creature is one of us

Psycho (1960)
Halloween (1978)
The Silence of the Lambs (1991)

Subgenre: Splatter movie—a horror movie that centerpieces blood and guts

Night of the Living Dead (1968)
The Evil Dead (1981)
Dead Alive (1990)

Subgenre: **J-HORROR**—a gruesome Japanese horror movie with a perverse psychological bent

Blind Beast (1969)
Cure (1997)
Audition (1999)

Subgenre: horror-comedy

Young Frankenstein (1974)
Attack of the Killer Tomatoes (1978)
Shaun of the Dead (2004)

*Night of the Day of the Dawn of the Son of the Bride of the Return of the
Revenge of the Terror of the Attack of the Evil, Mutant, Hellbound, Flesh-Eating
Subhumanoid Zombified Living Dead, Part 3* (2005)

GENRE: THE SEMANTIC/SYNTACTIC APPROACH

What role does history play in the formation, development, and possible decline of certain genres? How do we describe the way that

genres change over time and still remain consistent enough to be, in fact, genres? And what about variations that appear to defy genre definitions—westerns that don't take place in the American West, for instance? These are thorny questions.

The film scholar and theorist Rick Altman has proposed a model he calls the “**semantic/syntactic approach**” as a way of resolving these theoretical issues.³ The terms *semantic* and *syntactic* come from the field of linguistics, the study of language and its component parts. *Semantic* refers to *meaning*; *syntactic* has to do with *structuring and ordering*. Consider the word *horse*. Semantically, *horse* refers to a large four-legged, hoofed mammal. Syntactically, *horse* is a noun that may appear at any of a number of appropriate places in a sentence as long as its usage conforms to the rules of grammar. (The cowboy rode his *horse*. The *horse* had no saddle. On a *horse*, a person may travel more quickly than on foot. Etcetera.) Syntactically, the word *horse* may change positions in a sentence; its placement is variable, and a given sentence makes sense by virtue of where the word *horse* falls in it. Semantically, however, the word *horse* remains more or less constant in terms of its meaning, and it does not even have to be used in a sentence at all to have meaning. Think about it: *horse*. You know what the word means on its own.

According to Rick Altman, there have been two schools of critical thought and practice in genre studies: the semantic model on the one hand and the syntactic model on the other. Critics who study film genres *semantically* have concentrated on the similarities of characters, locations, lighting styles, and so on within a given genre—in other words, each genre has a set of relatively fixed meanings. Just as *horse* has a given meaning, so the western, or the horror film, or any genre or subgenre has a given meaning. *Syntactically* oriented scholars, in contrast, describe genres in terms of variable relationships between structured, ordered elements. Instead of stressing what remains constant within a genre, syntactic critics find a much more fluid and changeable set of films as constituting a consequently more fluid and changeable genre. Just as the word *horse* appears variably in sentences, the western, the comedy, or

any genre or subgenre appears variably over time and changes according to historical shifts, commercial decisions and economic trends, a specific director's individual concerns and visual style, and so on.

Altman uses as an example a semantic definition of the western offered by the French critic Jean Mitry: a western, for Mitry, is "a film whose action, situated in the American West, is consistent with the atmosphere, the values, and the conditions of existence in the Far West between 1840 and 1900." This is a fine example of a fixed, constant definition. For Mitry, it doesn't matter whether a film was made in 1909, 1959, or 2009: any film that is situated in the American West and has the values and atmosphere of the late nineteenth century is a western. There is something concrete about Mitry's definition—it's more or less stable and unchanging.

To provide a contrast, Altman cites the work of Jim Kitses as an example of a syntactic approach to the western. For Kitses, the western as a genre results from several overlapping thematic clashes: the West as desert versus the West as garden / nature versus culture / the individual versus the community. The fact that almost all westerns take place in the American West is actually of less interest to Kitses and other syntactic critics than the dialectics, or oppositional conflicts, that generate these films' narratives. For Kitses and others, the western is variable—it generates and regenerates all the time. Such constant regeneration crosses cultures as well as decades: Terrence Malick's *Badlands* (1973) can be considered a western, and even more flexibly, so can Ang Lee's *Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon* (2000), thanks to its use of western (and Western) conventions (like riding off into the sunset) and its theme of money and civilization encroaching on the old ways of the frontier.

The semantic definition is, frankly, easier to grasp than the syntactic, which depends on the abstract philosophical concept of dialectics, but the syntactic approach yields a more dynamic vision of what constitutes the growth, sustenance, and variation within genres. Moreover, as Altman notes, while the semantic definition has the virtue of being able to clearly describe and unify large numbers of

films, the syntactic definition makes it possible for us to isolate underlying themes and conflicts even though such isolated thematic clashes may not ultimately have broad applicability to every single film in a genre or subgenre. How do we resolve this apparent contradiction?

For Altman, and for the many film scholars he has influenced, these two schools of thought and practice are not opposites at all. Instead, they complement each other. Just as *horse* has both a semantic and a syntactic aspect, so genre criticism may point out both the relatively constant meaning of a given genre and its dynamic variability—similarities and differences, repetitions and variations.

One final note: what about those odd westerns that don't take place in the West? A 1939 film called *Allegheny Uprising*, starring John Wayne, contains a number of elements common to westerns—an outlaw/hero, Indians, a fort, a vision of life on the American frontier—but the film is set in colonial times in Pennsylvania's Allegheny Valley, well east of the Mississippi River (the conventional divide between East and West). Under Jean Mitry's semantic definition, *Allegheny Uprising* cannot be a western; it takes place in the East during the eighteenth century. But as Rick Altman points out, under the complementary semantic/syntactic model, films like *Allegheny Uprising* (and John Ford's *Drums Along the Mohawk*, 1939; Cecil B. DeMille's *Unconquered*, 1947; and others) are accounted for as westerns. These films, though located in the East, are nevertheless set on the American frontier, and they all provide variations of Kiteses' dialectical clashes between desert and garden (though the conflict is actually between *forest* and garden), individual and community, and nature and culture, all in the overarching context of American history. These films thus form a subgenre with a paradoxical name: the *eastern western*.

FILM NOIR: A CASE STUDY

One of the most intriguing genres in film history is the **film noir**. *Film Studies* focuses on this genre for several reasons: film noir has

readily identifiable themes, visual conventions, character conventions, and story conventions; it's a particularly homegrown American genre that says some surprising things about our culture; it raises some fascinating historical and theoretical questions; and classic film noirs often serve as key screenings in introductory film courses.

Film noir developed—and critics began to perceive it as a genre—at a specific point in history: the 1940s. After the end of World War II (1939–1945), American films—which had been banned under the Nazi occupation of France—cascaded back into French movie theaters. Thanks to the critical distance afforded to them by differences in language and culture, French critics noticed what Americans hadn't yet perceived, not consciously anyway: that during the previous few years, Hollywood had been producing a cycle of especially dark-tempered and morbid films. American audiences had been seeing and presumably enjoying these films for a year or two during the later years of the war, but it took some highly perceptive French critics *after* the war to see the repetition and variation of formal elements and narrative themes among a group of films, and on that basis they classified a new genre: *film noir*, or “black film.”

These films have an unusual emotional goal: they induce a sense of tension and *malaise* in their audiences. They're feel-bad movies. The male protagonists are usually troubled, and women are often deadly, vicious, alluring temptresses. The films often take place at night, in bad parts of town, with shadowy, low-key lighting and a lot of tough talk. It's an ugly world—a paranoid world. Urban and dirty. Full of greed, lust, and corruption. In short, film noir explores the dark side of American culture.

World War II certainly played a role in the genesis of film noir's gritty, grim moodiness, but it wasn't just the war's tensions and devastation that provoked and sustained the genre; film noir continued for many years after the war ended. In 1952, for instance, just when everybody was supposed to be happily building houses in the happy suburbs, the director Fritz Lang made a film noir called *The Big Heat* in which Lee Marvin's character throws a pot of scalding coffee right in Gloria Grahame's character's face in the

middle of the film. (Fortunately, she hurls another pot of equally hot coffee in Marvin's face later in the film, so she gets even.) A poster for *The Big Heat* featured the tag line, "Somebody's going to pay—because they forgot to kill me!" That's the perverse basis on which this particular film noir was sold to the public as mass entertainment in 1952: the protagonist (Glenn Ford) seeks vengeance for someone's failure to kill him.



FIGURE 10.1 A still from the classic film noir *Murder, My Sweet* (1944)—Mike Mazurki (*left*), Dick Powell (*right*). (Photofest)

Billy Wilder's *Double Indemnity* (1944) and Otto Preminger's *Laura* (1944) are widely considered to be not only two of the first film noirs but also two of the greatest and most definitive. (In the former, an insurance salesman plans the murder of one of his own clients with the aid of the client's killer-dame wife; in the latter, a detective investigating a murder finds himself falling disturbingly in love with the victim.) But film scholars have noted that John Huston's *The Maltese Falcon* and Orson Welles's *Citizen Kane*, both released three years earlier, in 1941, also contain elements of film noir, though scholars rarely classify them simply (or, better, solely) as film noirs.

Other notable film noirs from the mid-to-late 1940s are Howard Hawks's *The Big Sleep* and Fritz Lang's *Scarlet Street* (both 1945), Jacques Tourneur's *Out of the Past* (1947), and Jules Dassin's *The Naked City* (1948). In 1950 alone, the following noirs were released: *D.O.A.*, *Dark City*, *In a Lonely Place*, *No Way Out*, *Panic in the Streets*, *Where Danger Lives*, and *Where the Sidewalk Ends*. Their titles alone convey a sense of the genre's bleak emotional tenor. The fifties went on to feature many more downers: Lang's *Clash by Night* (1952), Samuel Fuller's *Pickup on South Street* (1953), Robert Aldrich's *Kiss Me Deadly* (1955), Alfred Hitchcock's *The Wrong Man* (1956), and Orson Welles's *Touch of Evil* (1958), to name only a few.

There is widespread disagreement about what happened to (or with) film noir as a genre from about 1960 to the present day. Some people think that film noir adapted over the years and still continues as an active genre today; they call these later films **neo-noirs** to distinguish them from those of the classic period. Still others see the genre as ending in the late 1950s and early 1960s and refuse to classify as film noir any film made thereafter. A few of the best-known films that fall into this disputed territory are Robert Altman's *The Long Goodbye* (1973), Roman Polanski's *Chinatown* (1974), Quentin Tarantino's *Reservoir Dogs* (1992), and Curtis Hanson's *L.A. Confidential* (1997). And what of Joel and Ethan Coen's *No Country for Old Men* (2007)? Could it be a *neo-noir western*?

FILM NOIR'S CONVENTIONS

Film noir's conventions are both thematic and formal. That is, there are great similarities among the stories and plots of these films, their central and secondary characters' occupations and personalities, what the films are about on a philosophical level, and the ways the films look and sound. These likenesses, after all, are what makes film noir a genre.

Many (though not all) film noirs feature a murder or multiple murders; on this basis alone, one can safely say that questions about violence, mortality, and death lie at the heart of the genre. Because a killing so often motivates the narratives of these films, many film noir protagonists are detectives who are hired to solve the case and nab the killer. There is thus an epistemological quest at the heart of the genre—a search for knowledge. (*Epistemology* is a branch of philosophy concerned with questions of *knowing*—as opposed to *ontology*, which is about *being*.)

One odd way the genre formalizes this epistemological quest is to feature especially convoluted stories with plotting that does not serve to clarify events but instead overcomplicates them. The detective/protagonist often serves as the audience's onscreen surrogate, trying to make sense not only of an apparently senseless murder but, by extension, a whole moral universe of confusion and meaninglessness. There is a *nihilistic* quality to these films—a sense of cold, cosmic hostility, a feeling that life is empty and nothing matters. The most illustrative example of noir's theme of uncertainty and disorder is Hawks's *The Big Sleep*, a film so convoluted and bewildering in its story and structure that halfway through the production Hawks reportedly sent a telegram to Raymond Chandler, the author of the novel on which the film is based, asking him to clarify something: who killed one of the characters? Chandler wired back that he had no idea.

Low-key lighting that creates ominous shadows, the striped effect of bright light shining into a dim room through Venetian blinds, and striking black-and-white cinematography—sometimes gritty, sometimes polished—are three of the most significant formal conventions of film noir. In fact, the presence or absence of black and white instead of color can be used to define what is and what is

not a film noir. Since all the original film noirs were made in black and white, later directors' use of color—Altman in *The Long Goodbye*, Polanski in *Chinatown*, Tarantino in *Reservoir Dogs*—may be seen as constituting so significant a variation from one of the genre's essential conventions that no color film can be, strictly speaking, a film noir. This is, of course, debatable, as all good points must be.

1. This is a clear and simple definition of the western, and it is problematic for that very reason. See below for a discussion of what makes it a problem.
2. This, too, is a problematically simple definition. Can *any* genre be defined accurately and thoroughly in just a few words? Why not?
3. Rick Altman, *Film/Genre* (London: British Film Institute, 1999).

STUDY GUIDE: GENRE ANALYSIS FOR THE INTRODUCTORY STUDENT

Studying genre presents a particular challenge for the beginning film student. While one can learn to describe mise-en-scene elements in detail by watching a five-minute clip from any film, for instance, studying a genre demands that one be familiar with at least several films within a particular genre, if not more. In fact, to fully appreciate what genre means from both historical and formal perspectives—to see the macro-picture of how films are classified by way of similarities—one needs to be familiar with a very large number of films. Apparently simple questions turn out to be surprisingly dependent on advanced knowledge:

- How does one genre differ from another?
- What role does history play in generating, sustaining, changing, and even eliminating genres and subgenres?

First-time film studies students must learn to ask these questions, but they can rarely answer them accurately on their own. Just as you cannot legitimately make claims about a director's worldview based on only one example of his or her work, so you must rein in any generalizations you might try to make about genres. Unless you bring extensive prior viewing experience to the table, you need a study guide that teaches you to learn independently about a subject that, by its nature, requires familiarity with large numbers of films.

So, start small. Deal with genre on a micro level.

Note the title of a movie you have seen recently (outside of class, that is), and attempt to classify it as a genre and/or subgenre. Don't simply name a genre right away, even if you think you know the answer. (And it's cheating to simply look it up online and accept someone else's genre classification.) Instead, take a more methodical approach by creating a taxonomic outline. Collect and enumerate facts, and use reason to deduce an answer. In simpler terms, identify the film's most noteworthy traits, and see if the results suggest that the film belongs to a particular genre and/or subgenre or whether the film is a mix of genres.

Here's an example:

***THE DARK KNIGHT* (Christopher Nolan, 2008)**

1. MISE-EN-SCENE ELEMENTS

- A. Color—does any color or tone predominate?
- B. Lighting—high key, low key, or a mix of both?

- C. Urban location
- D. Similarities with other art forms
 - i. Art form A
 - ii. Art form B
- E. Costumes
 - i. Bruce Wayne's costumes
 - ii. Batman's costume
 - iii. Other characters' costumes
- F. Makeup
 - i. Bruce Wayne's makeup
 - ii. The Joker's makeup
 - iii. Other characters' makeup

2. CHARACTER TYPES

- A. Bruce Wayne (Christian Bale)
- B. Batman (Christian Bale)
- C. The Joker (Heath Ledger)
- D. Rachel Dawes (Maggie Gyllenhaal)
- E. Harvey Dent/Two Face (Aaron Eckhart)
- F. Other characters

3. STORY AND PLOT ELEMENTS

- A. Central story events
- B. Daytime scenes vs. nighttime scenes
- C. Presence or absence of explicit violence (For instance, could *The Dark Knight* be a [splatter film](#)?)
- D. Plot structure
 - i. Presence or absence of flashbacks
 - ii. Plot twists / revelations

4. THEMES

- A. Dualities and secret identities
- B. Double crosses

Conclusion: *The Dark Knight* is a _____.

WRITING ABOUT GENRE

The key challenges when writing about genre are to confine your discussion to what you can prove you know and to avoid making claims you cannot support. You *can* write about *The Dark Knight*'s visual and aural style, its roots in another art form, and the moral questions the film raises. You can also analyze the Joker's makeup and costuming as particular expressions of the film's thematic concerns. You can write about any formal aspect of *The Dark Knight* that interests you—as long as you have seen *The Dark Knight*, that is.

What you should not attempt to do is tackle the too-broad topic of the superhero film by using *The Dark Knight* as an example. Why not? Well, for one thing, you will have

to have seen a number of superhero films in order to make any legitimate claims about the genre. *Fair enough*, you may counter; *I have seen* Superman (1978), Batman (1989), Darkman (1990), Spider-Man (2002), Ultraman (2004), Mercury Man (2006), and The Adventures of Sharkboy and Lavagirl 3-D (2005), so why can't I write about them?

The answer is, *you can try*. And you may succeed—but only if you deal with these films in specific, concrete detail. Do you remember them so well that you can describe and analyze their mise-en-scenes effectively? If so, great! To do it well, you would end up with at least a 10- to 12-page paper, if not a much longer one. A better idea is to tailor your genre paper's topic. It's always better to write a shorter, tighter paper that proves you know what you're talking about than a longer, flabbier paper full of generalizations and vague descriptions.

When writing a paper about genre—unless your professor gives you a specific assignment that differs, of course—use these three guidelines to form your topic and shape the paper:

1. **Construct a provable thesis.** The thesis of your paper is its argument—what you are setting out to prove. For example, you will not be able to prove anything about all superhero movies in an average-length college paper. You don't have enough space, let alone knowledge. You *can* prove, however, that *The Dark Knight*, a single superhero movie, is about moral relativism, or that its protagonist has something in common with its villain, or that particular aspects of its mise-en-scene visually express the gloom suggested by its title. Your best bet is to particularize your thesis as much as possible to an individual film, and leave broader arguments about entire genres to upper-level film classes.
2. **Stay focused on the film in question.** Having constructed a provable thesis that confines itself to a particular aspect of a single movie, stick to it. If you find yourself beginning a sentence with the phrase "Most superhero movies" or anything like it, delete it immediately and start again. You are not writing about most superhero movies. You are writing about *The Dark Knight*.
3. **If you can't help yourself and are compelled to mention something about an entire genre or subgenre, cite an expert.** Let's face it: professors are looking for things to object to in your papers. (That's what we do. It's in our contract.) It is much more difficult for professors to object to any broad claim you make about a genre (or any subject) if you can find a film scholar to say it for you. For example:

- *Unacceptable*: "Most superhero movies feature protagonists who have a single superpower and a one-dimensional personality to match."—Timothy Burton, freshman, Middlebury College
- *Acceptable*: "According to the critic and film scholar Vicki Vale in the journal *Annals of Cinematicity*, 'Most superhero movies feature protagonists who have a single superpower and a one-dimensional personality to match' (Vale, p. 373).—Jim Gordon, sophomore, Haverford College